A Short Guide to Reading Maps

1. Scales and symbols

A map is a flat picture of a place. The scale tells you how a distance on the paper relates to the real distance on the ground. For example, a scale of one to fifty thousand means that one centimetre on the map stands for half a kilometre in the world.

Symbols save space. A small blue line usually shows a river, a green patch shows a forest, and a thin black line shows a road. The legend, often printed in a corner of the sheet, explains every symbol that the mapmaker used.

Before a long walk, check the scale first. Measure the route with a piece of string, then compare the string against the scale bar to estimate how far you will travel.

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2. Directions and contour lines

Most maps are drawn with north at the top. A small arrow near the edge confirms the direction, and a compass helps you line the map up with the land around you.

Contour lines connect points of equal height. When the lines sit close together the slope is steep, and when they are far apart the ground is almost flat. A set of closed circles usually marks the top of a hill.

With practice you can read a map the way you read a page of text: scan the legend, find your position, pick a landmark, and follow the lines to the place you want to reach.